

# The Churning Tide

**The India-Australia Test series starting next week will mark the moment of truth for India's Big Five**

■ By Sharda Ugra

**L**ess than a year after they clashed helmets and egos in the southern hemisphere, India and Australia will go at each other again. This will be their sixth bilateral series in seven years and the cricket always has been memorable. The nerves can still expect as much calm as is found by lighting firecrackers under furniture.

When these two contradictory adversaries meet, expect everything. Quality, intensity, anxiety.

For India, the upcoming four-Test series for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy is loaded with anxiety, and not merely because it's Australia on the other side. Unlike most other international teams, Anil Kumble and his men know how to tackle and overcome Australia and exactly just how much respect is too much respect.

India's anxiety stems from the fact that over the next month, its most accomplished players will take on the Australians knowing that every innings will mark a fresh judgement day. It may not be fair to men of great achievement and ability, but it is the unforgiving law of their profession.

India vs Australia usually produces sweeping sagas featuring more than runs, wickets, victory and defeats. The rivalry throws up great themes: character, pride, revenge, redemption. This one will also contain five separate epics and Kumble and his batting colleagues know that tragic endings are not an option.

It was the Test team's meltdown in Sri Lanka and the contrasting surge from the ODI squad that has caused faith to leak from India's core. In the

space of a few tussles with a freak bowler, India and its finest, with the exception of V.V.S. Laxman, were reminded of mortality. These men must now take on the most successful team of this millennium to a soundtrack composed of the murmurs of doubt and the ticking of the clock.

The return of Sourav Ganguly after being left out both of the Irani Trophy and a preparatory camp has come accompanied, predictably, by a cacophony of rumours. Is this the prince's

possible that Ganguly's inclusion is acknowledgement of his priceless ability to irritate Australians by merely walking into a room, and comes with the hope that the old drama king still has a couple of soliloquies left in him.

What is also abundantly clear now is that India's handover of generations is going to be bumpy and messy. None of that is the fault of the stalwarts. Their anointed successors have failed to step up to the plate with any confidence and some vintage BCCI idiocy has not helped matters either. A completely new selection committee has had to pick a team for a major series in just over 72 hours following their appointment.

This mocks the very purpose of balancing continuity with succession planning. The previous committee headed by Dilip Vengsarkar took decisions both inspired and contentious, but there was never any doubt that they did not know where they were heading. The BCCI's calendar led them to a premature finish, a situation that could have been avoided by applying common sense. But, of course, that's not as abundantly found in Indian cricket as money.

India has only to look across at Australia to see what it means to lose

titans. Ricky Ponting & Co have arrived with their ceremonial trumpeting (and a seasoned trumpeter in the form of Greg Chappell), but a swift run-through their team sheet makes it all sound a trifle hollow.

Both sides are struggling against the tides of time, but India and its greatest crop of Test players have much more to lose. ■

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**With every innings, India's most experienced players will face a fresh judgement day.**

Golden Handshake? Is this the way it's going to end for all of them? In a series of 'deals' designed to ensure that the selectors don't have to do their jobs?

Deal-making would be demeaning to the cricketers and to their sport. By itself, retirement is a prickly business and for champions to so compromise themselves would indeed be far worse than a duck in your final innings. It is